集装箱：重塑世界的铁盒子

The Steel Box That Remade the World



一个普通铁箱，怎样改变了全球货运？

英文原文

On 26 April 1956 a **converted** Second World War **tanker**, the Ideal X, **slipped out of** Port Newark, New Jersey, for Houston. **Clamped** to her deck were 58 **containers**, **trailer** bodies **detached from** their **wheels** and **chassis**. Few **spectators** would have taken so **unremarkable** a **cargo** for a **landmark**.

At the time, **freight** travelled **loose**. **Gangs** of twenty or more **dockworkers** carried **sacks**, **barrels**, and **crates** piece by piece. It was **strenuous drudgery**. Ships could spend **up to** half their time **berthed**, and **theft** was **rampant**. In 1956 **loading** loose cargo cost about $5.83 a ton; loading the Ideal X cost, **by** the company's **reckoning**, about 16 cents.

Containers were not new. The **hurdle** was **consensus**: **rival** firms' boxes had **incompatible dimensions** and **latches**. An **international standards** committee formed in 1961. In January 1963 Sea-Land, the Ideal X's renamed operator, let the committee use its **patents** free of **royalties**, including those on corner **fittings** for **hoisting**. Lifted by **crane**, a box could be **transferred smoothly** between ship, **lorry**, and train.

This **efficiency** came **at the expense of livelihoods**. New York's **waterfront employment shrank** by about three quarters between 1963 and 1976. Much of the cargo crossed the harbour to a new **terminal** at Elizabeth, **inaugurated** in August 1962. Most of London's **historic docks** closed one after another from 1967 to 1980, while Felixstowe, on the Suffolk coast, **expanded**.

The **rewards** were **substantial**. A study published in the Journal of International **Economics** in 2016 estimated that containerisation had lifted trade between **industrialised** countries by a **cumulative** 700 per cent over 20 years. **Tireless** cranes now lift **identical** containers into **orderly**, **immense stacks**.

中文译文

1956年4月26日，一艘改造过的二战油轮“理想X号”，悄然驶离新泽西州纽瓦克港，开往休斯敦。固定在她甲板上的是58个集装箱，其实就是从车轮和底盘上拆卸下来的挂车车厢。极少数旁观者会把一批如此平淡无奇的货物当作一个里程碑。

那时，货物都是散装运输。一帮二十多名或更多的码头工人，一件件地搬运麻袋、桶和板条箱。这是繁重的/费力的苦差事。船舶可能会花多达一半的时间停泊在港，而且偷窃猖獗。1956年，装载散货每吨花费约5.83美元；据公司估算，装载理想X号花费约16美分。

集装箱并不新鲜。障碍在于共识：竞争对手公司的箱子有互不兼容的尺寸和门闩/锁扣。1961年，一个国际标准委员会成立。1963年1月，海陆公司，即理想X号更名后的运营方，允许该委员会使用其专利，不收取专利费，包括用于吊装的角配件上的那些专利。由吊机吊起，一只箱子便能在船舶、卡车和火车之间顺畅地转运。

这种效率是以生计为代价换来的。纽约海滨区的就业人数在1963年至1976年间缩减了约四分之三。大量货物穿过港湾，前往伊丽莎白一处于1962年8月启用的新码头/港区。1967年到1980年，伦敦历史悠久的码头一个接一个地关闭，而位于萨福克海岸的费利克斯托则扩张了。

回报相当可观。一项2016年发表于《国际经济学杂志》的研究估计，集装箱化在20年间使工业化国家之间的贸易提高了累计700%。如今，不知疲倦的吊机把一模一样的集装箱吊起，码成整齐的、巨大的箱垛。

词汇与表达

converted adj.
改造过的

tanker n.
油轮

slipped out of v.
悄然驶离

Clamped v.
固定

containers n.
集装箱

trailer n.
挂车

detached from v.
从……上拆卸下来的

wheels n.
车轮

chassis n.
底盘

spectators n.
旁观者

unremarkable adj.
平淡无奇的

cargo n.
货物
so unremarkable a cargo

landmark n.
里程碑
a cargo for a landmark

freight n.
货物
freight travelled loose

loose adj.
散装

Gangs n.
帮

dockworkers n.
码头工人

sacks n.
麻袋

barrels n.
桶

crates n.
板条箱

strenuous adj.
繁重的/费力的

drudgery n.
苦差事
strenuous drudgery

up to prep.
多达

词汇与表达（续）

berthed v.
停泊

theft n.
偷窃

rampant adj.
猖獗
theft was rampant

loading n.
装载

by reckoning phr.
据……估算

hurdle n.
障碍
The hurdle was consensus

consensus n.
共识
The hurdle was consensus

rival adj.
竞争对手

incompatible adj.
互不兼容的
incompatible dimensions and latches

dimensions n.
尺寸
incompatible dimensions and latches

latches n.
门闩/锁扣

international standards n.
国际标准

patents n.
专利
use its patents free of royalties

royalties n.
专利费
use its patents free of royalties

fittings n.
配件

hoisting v.
吊装

crane n.
吊机
Lifted by crane

transferred v.
转运
could be transferred smoothly

smoothly adv.
顺畅地

lorry n.
卡车

词汇与表达（续）

efficiency n.
效率
This efficiency came

at the expense of n.
以……为代价
at the expense of livelihoods

livelihoods n.
生计
at the expense of livelihoods

waterfront n.
海滨区

employment n.
就业人数
waterfront employment shrank

shrank v.
缩减了

terminal n.
码头/港区

inaugurated v.
启用
inaugurated in August 1962

historic adj.
历史悠久的

docks n.
码头

expanded v.
扩张了

rewards n.
回报

substantial adj.
可观
The rewards were substantial

Economics n.
经济学

industrialised adj.
工业化

cumulative adj.
累计
a cumulative 700 per cent

Tireless adj.
不知疲倦的

identical adj.
一模一样的
lift identical containers

orderly adj.
整齐的

immense adj.
巨大的

stacks n.
箱垛

文章简述

- 启航：过去码头逐件搬散货，船常久停；1956年，理想X号载58个集装箱启航。
- 降本：据运营方估算，该船每吨装船费约0.16美元，远低于当时散货的5.83美元。
- 互通：各家箱型原不兼容；运营方海陆公司免费开放专利，推动标准统一，箱子可在船、卡车和火车间转运。
- 转移：货运转向新港，老码头和工人生计受冲击；1963至1976年，纽约滨水区就业缩减约四分之三。
- 回报：2016年一项研究估计，集装箱化在20年间使工业化国家间贸易累计增加约700%。